

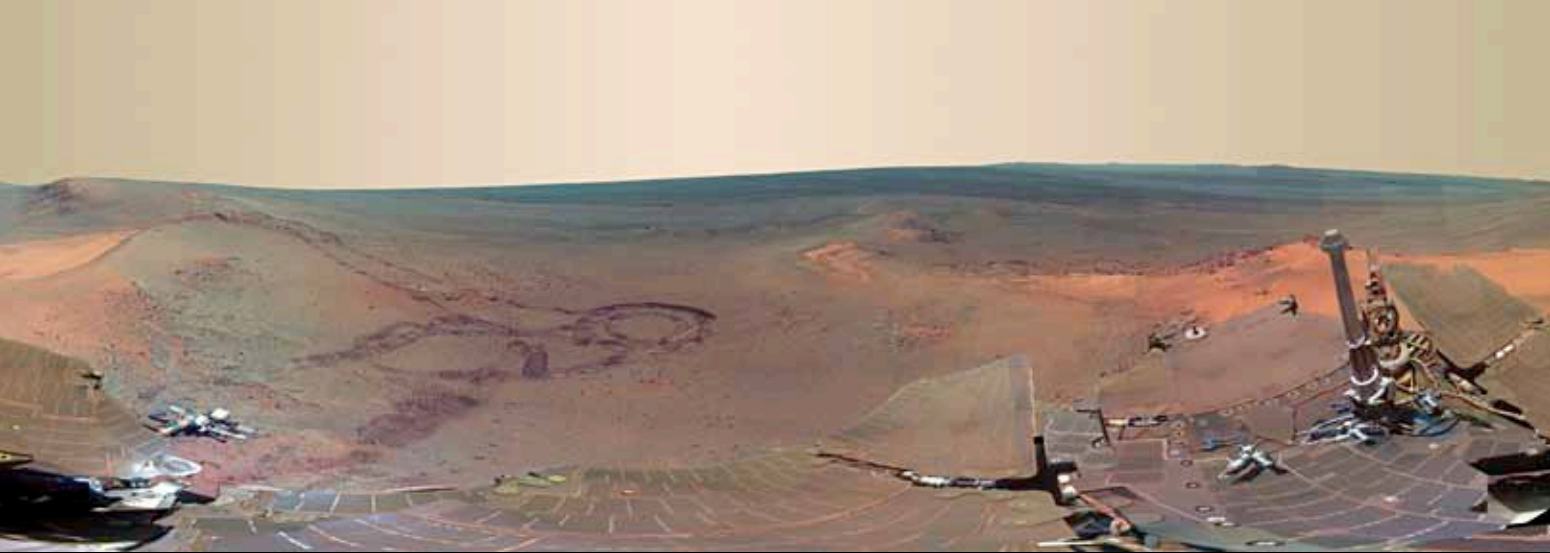
## Explorer's heritage of Antarctica

Google's street view just became more interesting with Google adding 360 degree images of the South Pole and that of the housed used as base camps by early South pole explorers



## Habitable exoplanets?

Read up on Gliese 581g, the best candidate for an Earth-like exoplanet so far and four others here. <http://digit.in/NGh2g7>



# EXPLORING MARS A HISTORY AND THE FUTURE

Mars is a planet that has long held our imaginations. We take a look at the story behind the red planet and what we've accomplished so far

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Of all the planets in the solar system, for some reason it has always been Mars that we associate with life, the future hope of us humans, among many other number of things. Why is that? Why not Venus, or one of Jupiter's moons? What is so special about this red planet that has captured our imagination so?

### 16th-18th Century - Hope!

Mars has been under observation since the time of the Ancient Greeks and Romans. Even at that time it was called the red planet and was claimed to be a herald to War and destruction. It was only in the early 16th century, with the invention of the early telescopes, that the "astronomers" of that time started observing Mars. It was Christiaan Huygens who observed bright and dark spots on the surface of Mars, features he thought resembled caches of water. Sometime around 1672, Huygens and his nephew, Cassini, thought that they

could see clouds and surface features on the red planet. They were wrong about the clouds of course, which later turned out to be massive dust storms, but they did notice the polar ice caps. These observations seemed to indicate the presence of water and even a proper atmosphere, a clear indicator that life was possible and that it probably already existed on the surface. It was only in the early 18th century however, that William Herschel and his sister, Caroline, confirmed the presence of the polar ice caps on the Martian surface.

Venus would have been far easier to observe at the time, being the closest planet to Earth. It would in fact have been the logical place to look for life on,



Global dust-storms can obscure the Martian surface

being of a similar size to Earth. The planet however is shrouded in clouds of sulphur, impossible to penetrate using the visible spectrum of light. To the astronomers at the time, Venus was just another white disk in the sky and compared to that, Mars seemed to be full of promise.

### 18th-19th Century - Life!

This was the century where "conclusive" proof of life on Mars was found. This speculation started when Giovanni Schiaparelli started mapping the surface of Mars. He assumed that dark spots were the seas and oceans and he called the lines Canali ("canals" in Latin). This is where the trouble began, people misunderstood and assumed that Giovanni was talking about actual canals. It never occurred to anyone that features as small as canals were impossible to observe at the time.

This misconception is the equivalent of saying that God exists because the God particle exists. Either way, someone heard that there were canals on Mars, people started imagining that they were seeing them too and the idea was stuck. Canals = intelligent life, so Mars had intelligent life. It seemed an obvious conclusion at the time. It was even theorised at the time that the Martians built canals all the way from the ice caps so as to irrigate their dying